

Martial Arts

In the world of *Oriental Adventures*, the martial arts are a style of combat that never developed significantly in the rest of the AD&D® game world. It is perhaps one of the most unique features of this land—the development of the body into a useful weapon, capable of defeating opponents supposedly better armed and armored than the unarmed fighter. The unarmed fighter uses his entire body—his hands, feet, legs, arms, head—any part can be turned into a weapon. To achieve this skill, he must undergo rigorous training. This training requires great physical and mental discipline to master the styles, maneuvers, and feats of the martial arts. The unarmed fighter must learn to anticipate actions, harden his body, block out pain, and summon energies from deep within himself. This is not easy and requires a deep commitment on the part of the character.

There are several reasons why the martial arts have been developed to such a high degree within this society. Part of it is the philosophy and outlook of the people. Found throughout all the lands is a belief in the forces of nature. These forces are not just abstract concepts, they surround the character and charge everything about him with hidden energies. Nor is the character a passive observer of these forces. He is part of them, just as they are part of him. Therefore, he too can draw upon these forces and use them. Furthermore, he strives to live in harmony with these forces, perhaps appeasing them with offerings and prayers or learning to commune and understand them. But before he can do this, he must learn, develop, and harmonize the forces within himself. By doing so, he is able to live at peace with the natural forces. While tools can be effective in changing the face of nature, they are outside this harmony, they intrude upon it. Understanding one's own body and its capabilities is thus one factor leading to the development of unarmed fighting skills.

Several religious beliefs espouse the idea that this world is a passing thing, that with time, everything will change. As such, material possessions have little real worth or value—they are not permanent. Devout followers of these beliefs try to divest themselves of the desire for the material world, since these are impediments to ultimate perfection. Only the inner qualities of a man are permanent and positively known. Reliance upon a tool such as a weapon is reliance upon the material world. Only by knowing themselves and their own value can they achieve perfection. Thus, they learn and develop their own abilities to understand themselves.

There are other, more pressing social reasons for the development of unarmed fighting. The Oriental society is not like the other societies of the world. Where the peasant of another land always keeps and feels entitled to carry a sword or similar weapon, it is not unusual in the lands of *Oriental Adventures* for severe edicts to be passed restricting the ownership of

such weapons. This is particularly true in conquered lands and notoriously troublesome provinces. Punishments could be quite severe, including torture and execution. Given these restraints, commoners often had to find other ways to defend themselves.

In time, these skills became widely practiced and honorable. Efforts were made to regularize the styles and training practices. Careful study of scientific principles and religious concepts followed. Unarmed fighting became an art which if practiced diligently and correctly could guide the student to self-perfection.

With the spread of martial arts skill, every land developed its own styles. The fighter had to learn to counter weapons favored in the local area and studied the natural styles of the beasts of his land. Each style was further divided by the masters who taught it. Each developed his own particular moves and methods and two masters of the same style could easily fight in entirely different forms. Thus, there grew a vast proliferation of methods of martial arts, some might favor use of the feet while others might rely on evasion and throws and so forth. Arguments and challenges over which style was better were quite common, as fighters of different schools sought to establish the supremacy of their claim. These were often spectator events, with hundreds of interested onlookers.

At the lowest level, the martial arts train the fighter in the use of his body. The primary goal is to train the fighter so that he can avoid being hurt. However, different masters espouse different ways of reaching this goal. Some styles are mainly defensive, diverting or avoiding the attack. Other styles are more aggressive, their masters believing that attacking is the best way to protect oneself. Others demand the fighter learn and master many different weapons to understand their use.

Unarmed combat uses many different techniques, depending mainly on the style learned. Forms include punches, blocks, kicks, pushes, throws, holds, locks, and dodges—a near infinite variety of moves. Unarmed combat is also a misnomer. Students are often expected to learn how to handle common and unusual weapons. However, using many of these weapons effectively requires the same discipline and training as the unarmed or open-hand forms and so their use is only taught as part of a particular martial arts style. To give a peasant a tui-fu and expect him to fight with it effectively is foolish, but in the hands of a master of martial arts it can become a deadly weapon.

This section covers how martial arts skills are learned and used in combat. Some of the styles described are historical. But, as noted above, there can be hundreds of different styles, so a part of these rules describe how the DM can create different and unique styles as befits the campaign. One never knows when there might be a hermit in the hills who has developed a new fighting style!

The martial arts given here are designed to fit within the rules the AD&D® game. Players should not expect a detailed listing of every type of combat move, thrust, or parry that

combine to make a complete style. Styles are defined by their effects within the rules—number of attacks, damage, armor class, and principal attack form. As characters rise in levels, they may also learn a number of specialized maneuvers inherent to a style. However, such powers only come with dedication and training!

Styles

Under *Oriental Adventures* rules, the martial arts are classified by five different characteristics—number of attacks, damage, armor class, principal attack form, and special maneuvers. When grouped together, these elements form a style. There can be as many styles as there are possible combinations of these elements. Each style is different and must be learned separately. Styles are often given descriptive or poetic names, based on how the style works, its appearance when used, or the source of inspiration. There are animal names (Snake, Monkey, Tiger, etc.), poetic names (Eight Drunken Fairies), and descriptive names (Empty Hand, Springing Legs, Eight Fists, etc.). Each identifies a particular style. In addition, styles are further identified by their use. Some are highly defensive, relying on the inner power of the user to overcome the opponent; others are aggressive, stressing form and channeled power in hard and sudden attacks. Below are listed some common styles.

Table 68: COMMON MARTIAL STYLES

Name	# of At.	Damage	AC	Principal Attack	Special Maneuvers
Karate	3/1	1-6	8	Hand	Strike 1, 2, 3 / Kick 1 / Movement 1 / Mental 1
Kung-fu	2/1	1-6	6	Hand	Lock 1, 2, 3 / Strike 1, 2 / Kick 2 / Movement 4 / Mental 5
Tae Kwon Do	1/1	1-8	8	Foot	Kick 1, 2, 3 / Strike 1 / Throw 4 / Movement 5
Jujutsu	2/1	1-6	7	Hand	Throw 1, 2, 3, 4 / Movement 1, 3 / Vital Area 1, 2 / Mental 1, 2, 3

Number of attacks functions in the same manner as it does for normal combat. When using martial arts, the number of attacks depends on the style used and may differ from the number of attacks with weapons. Thus a character's ability to attack may increase, decrease or remain the same when using martial arts.

Damage is the die that is rolled to determine the effect of a hit. Defensive styles generally do low damage; offensive styles have the opposite effect.

Armor class is a measure of the degree of protection the character gains when using the style. This protection comes from the character's training which may allow him to avoid, deflect, or withstand blows.

Principal attack form is the part or parts of the body most often used in the style. So long as the character has the listed body part free he can continue to make effective attacks. Karate emphasizes the fist, so the character can attack even though his legs may be held. Other styles use the legs, elbows, torso, etc.

Special maneuvers are the secrets of the art, secrets that allow fantastic feats, but are difficult to learn. These include things such as Backward Kick, Sticking Touch, Great Throw, Ironskin, and other normally impossible abilities.

Creating a Style

In addition to using the common styles already listed, the DM is encouraged to create new styles for use in his campaign. These styles are taught by various NPC masters. A style is created by choosing the general characteristics of the style and then selecting values, terms, and abilities from the lists given in the text.

The DM should first decide whether the style is hard, soft, or a combination of the two. Hard styles emphasize the use of the muscles and bones for power. They usually use very direct movements and are generally offensive, stressing the attack. Soft styles rely more on the inner power of the character to provide the necessary energy, although they too require conditioning of the muscles. Their movements are much more fluid and circular and are generally considered more defensive. These movements divert the attacker, using his own force against him, and making an attack only after the enemy has committed himself. The training is more mentally oriented, showing the student how to focus and use his inner power. Styles that combine both hard and soft attempt to use the best practices from each. Circular and gentle defensive movements are combined with swift and direct attacks. Physical training is balanced with psychic training. All styles can make use of a number of unusual weapons.

Next, the DM must choose the principal method of the style, the fighting method most commonly used in the style. When a character attacks, he more often than not uses the principal method of the style. Each principal method describes the most common means of attack—those with kicking method use many kicks, those with throwing rely on grappling and leverage, etc. However, every style incorporates moves from other methods, since reliance on a single form would certainly mean defeat.

Table 69: Martial Style Combinations lists all the different choices available for creating a style. As the DM makes selections, his choices determine the armor class, number of attacks, damage, and body part used by the style.

Table 69: MARTIAL STYLE COMBINATIONS

Form

Form	AC Mod.	#AT Mod.	Damage Mod.	Body Part
Hard	1	1	4	—
Soft	3	0	2	—
Hard/Soft	2	1	3	—

Principal Method

Method	AC Mod.	#AT Mod.	Damage Mod.	Body Part
Kick	1	1	4	Foot
Lock	1	1	2	Body
Movement	2	1	2	Legs
Push	2	1	1	Hand
Strike	1	1	4	Hand
Throw	1	1	2	Body
Vital area	2	1	4	Hand and foot
Weapon	1	1	by weapon	Hand and arm

Notes Regarding Style Combination Table

Form/Principal Method—The DM must select one form and one principal method for each style.

AC Mod.—Total the AC Mod. from the form and the method chosen. Subtract this number from 10 to get the Armor Class of the style.

#AT Mod.—Total the #AT Mod. from the form and the method chosen. This is the number of attacks allowed in a melee round when fighting in this style. This number of attacks does

not apply for any other style or when fighting with normal weapons.

Damage Mod.—Total the Damage Mod. from the form and the method chosen. Round this number (up) to the nearest die size used in the game. Thus, a total of 6 equals 1d6. A total of 4 equals 1d4. A total of 5 equals 1d6. This is the basic amount of damage done when fighting in the style.

Body Part—This lists the part or parts of the body most commonly used when fighting in this style. Kicking relies on the feet, while throwing makes use of the whole body. So long as a character has the listed body part unbound or free to move, the character can still attack effectively with that particular martial arts style.

In addition to the basic information concerning the style of the martial art, the referee must also determine what weapons (if any) are taught under the style. The DM rolls 1d4 and subtracts two from the result. This is the number of weapons that are taught under this particular style of martial arts. The DM can select the weapons from those that can be used in martial arts only.

Finally, the DM must determine the special maneuvers used by the style. This is explained in the next section, Special Maneuvers.

Special Maneuvers

Special maneuvers are actions and abilities that require intensive study and skill to learn. In return, they give the user greater-than-normal results and can be used to great effect. Some maneuvers are actions that the character can attempt during the course of a fight (Flying Kick, One Finger, etc.), others are constant abilities that once learned are always in effect (Ironskin, Blind Fighting, etc.). Combat maneuvers are risky in that failure often leaves the character in an exposed or dangerous position. A combat maneuver costs the character one or more of his attacks for the melee round. A movement maneuver counts as movement, preventing the character from making any attacks that round (unless the maneuver notes otherwise).

All maneuvers are organized according to the principal method of fighting used. Kicking covers actions involving kicks; movement includes leaps, tumbles, dives, and acrobatics. In addition, each maneuver is identified as being hard, soft, or hard/soft. This corresponds to the general classification of the fighting style. A soft fighting style mainly uses soft special maneuvers and a hard style uses hard special maneuvers. This does not prevent crossover between the two styles, it just indicates the general type of maneuver each style uses.

To determine the number of special maneuvers taught by the style, roll 1d8. This is the number of special maneuvers that can be chosen only from the principal method of the style or from the Mental and Physical Training lists. Then, a second roll of 1-3 is made to find the

number of maneuvers chosen from other methods (or again the Mental and Physical Training category). All styles usually incorporate a few maneuvers from other methods to provide the character with an arsenal of tactics.

The special maneuvers of each method are ranked according to the difficulty of each maneuver. The lower the number of the maneuver, the easier it is to learn and execute. When selecting the special maneuvers, there must be a progression from 1 on up. However, the progression does not need to be within a single principal method and there can be more than one maneuver at the same difficulty level. A style could begin with Circle Kick (1), Flying Kick (2), All-around Sight (2), and end with Backward Kick (3). The ranking is given to determine the order in which the abilities are gained. A higher difficulty maneuver can only be learned if those beneath it have already been learned.

Special maneuvers are not gained immediately upon learning the martial art style. They require extra training and are learned gradually. How these maneuvers (and martial arts proficiencies in general) are gained is explained under Learning Martial Arts.

In addition to the maneuvers grouped under the principal method, there is the additional category of Mental and Physical Training. These are special maneuvers that can be learned in any style because of the methods of practice and discipline of the training.

Table 70: MARTIAL ARTS SPECIAL MANEUVERS

Kick

1. Circle kick (hard)
2. Flying kick (hard)
3. Backward kick (hard/soft)

Lock

1. Choke hold (hard/soft)
2. Locking block (soft)
3. Incapacitator (hard/soft)
4. Immobilizing (hard/soft)

Movement

1. Feint (hard/soft)
2. Prone fighting (soft)
3. Immovability (soft)

4. Missile deflection (soft)
5. Leap (soft)
6. Speed (hard/soft)
7. Slow resistance (hard/soft)

Push

1. Concentrated push (soft)
2. Sticking touch (soft)
3. One finger (soft)

Strike

1. Iron fist (hard)
2. Crushing blow (hard)
3. Eagle claw (hard)

Throw

1. Fall (hard/soft)
2. Instant stand (hard/soft)
3. Hurl (hard)
4. Great throw (soft)

Vital Area

1. Pain touch (soft)
2. Stunning touch (soft)
3. Paralyzing touch (soft)
4. Distance death (soft)

Weapon

1. Weapon catch (hard/soft)
2. Weapon breaker (hard/soft)
3. Steel cloth (soft)

Mental and Physical Training

1. Meditation (hard/soft)
2. All-around sight (soft)
3. Mental resistance (soft)
4. Blind fighting (soft)
5. Ironskin (hard)
6. Levitation (soft)

Principal Methods

Kick

Circle Kick: In this dramatic kick, the attacker builds up power and momentum by spinning in a complete circle before landing the kick (usually on the side of the head or body). If successful (a normal to hit roll), the kick does twice normal damage. If unsuccessful, the character loses the next attack as he is normally allowed as he tries to recover his balance.

Flying Kick: This spectacular kick requires at least five feet of running space. The character leaps high into the air and leads with a powerful kick to the head (or head height for larger than man-sized creatures). If the kick connects, the character does triple normal damage. If unsuccessful, the character falls to the ground adjacent to the intended target and must spend a round getting back to his feet (unless he also has Prone Fighting or Instant Stand).

Backward Kick: This seemingly innocuous kick is extremely difficult to master. The character attempts a normal attack at any creature directly behind him, either kicking his foot over and behind his own head or lashing out straight backward. He does not have to turn around and face his attacker. The kick does normal damage, but a failed attempt has no ill effects.

Lock

Locking is the art of gripping an opponent in such a way that prevents him from acting—twisting an arm so the joint is locked, applying pressure to choke off breathing and blood flow, etc.

Choke Hold: This teaches the character the correct way of applying pressure to render an opponent unconscious. When using a choke hold, no attacks can be made in the next round as the attacker is entirely occupied in gripping and holding his opponent. If a successful to hit roll is made, the choke has been applied. Once applied, the hold must be maintained until

the end of the next melee round (during which the character can take no other action). The victim can attempt to escape by making a successful to hit roll, modified by a -2 on the die roll. The escape attempt can be tried as many times as the victim has attacks. If the character fails to escape, he falls unconscious at the end of the round. He remains unconscious for 1-3 rounds.

Locking Block: This action can be attempted instead of a normal attack. It can be used against other unarmed fighters or melee weapon attacks. A normal to hit roll is made. If successful, the character has trapped his opponent's weapon, arm, or leg in a scissors arm-lock and it cannot be used to make attacks. In addition, so long as the victim is so trapped the character can make attacks (using the feet only) with a +4 on his chance to hit. The victim can break the lock by expending an attack and making a normal to hit roll for success. The locking block does not cause damage.

When used against an unarmed fighter, an unsuccessful locking block causes no penalty other than the fact that the attack has been lost and no damage is done. However, when used against a weapon, an unsuccessful locking block results in the character taking damage from the weapon. In attempting to make the block, the character has only managed to get himself hit by the weapon.

Incapacitator: By gripping the opponent and twisting the joints, the character can render one finger, arm, or leg useless for 24 hours and cause double normal damage. The effects of incapacitating a limb are explained under the wu jen *withering palm* spell. A successful to hit roll must be made and the victim is allowed a saving throw vs. paralyzation. If the saving throw is failed, the appropriate limb is rendered useless. If the saving throw is made, the attack fails. An unsuccessful attack (either a failed to hit or a successful saving throw) has no effect on the attacker other than the waste of an attack and the lack of damage done. This maneuver is particularly useful to prevent opponents from escaping or making attacks.

Immobilizing: With one hand the character is able to grip and hold an opponent in a way that keeps him from taking any action. The character is still able to make attacks (using either his feet or his other hand), even applying an immobilizing lock on another victim. A successful to hit roll must be made and the attack does no damage. Immobilized characters can attempt to escape by spending a melee attack to break the hold. However, the chance of success is modified by -6 to the die roll. An unsuccessful immobilizing lock results in a -4 modifier on the character's next attack.

Movement

This method relies on the training of the character in the control and positioning of his own body—his posture, stance, and reflexes. From it students learn the importance of speed, sudden changes of direction, and footwork. It is seldom very offensive, but when combined with other styles creates a dangerous and deadly fighter.

Feint: A feint is a trick where the character begins an attack in one direction and at the last minute changes it to another direction. When done successfully, the opponent is out of position to the new attack and cannot defend as effectively against it. A feint requires one melee attack to execute. A normal to hit roll is made and if successful the character's next attack gains a +2 on the chance to hit. The feint itself does no damage. If unsuccessful, the character suffers no penalty other than the loss of the attack.

Prone Fighting: Prepared for any circumstance, the character is able to fight effectively even when lying on the ground. This special maneuver is constant—it applies any time the character is knocked from his feet. The only limitation is that the character can perform no other special maneuver (except Instant Stand) when prone.

Immovability: By carefully positioning his feet and learning to tense and relax various muscles, the character can avoid being knocked, lifted, or thrown off his feet. Any time these would occur, the character is automatically allowed a saving throw vs. paralyzation. If the save is successful, the character remains where he is.

Missile Deflection: Relying on the speed of his reflexes and the nimbleness of his footwork, the character is sometimes able to avoid non-magical missile attacks (including magical arrows and bolts). This ability is constant although the character must be aware of the attack. The character is allowed a saving throw vs. paralyzation against each attack. If the save is successful, the character has dodged the missile; if not, the missile hits normally.

Leap: The character is able to perform extraordinary feats of springing and leaping by channeling his inner power, mentally making himself as light as a feather. From a standing start the character can spring four feet into the air and three feet forward plus one foot for each level of the character. He can also flip in mid-air to automatically change his facing. Such springs do not take an entire melee round, costing instead only one attack allowed during the round. Thus a character could flip over an opponent, land behind him, and execute an attack from the rear with his next melee attack. From a running start, the character can spring eight feet upward and ten feet forward plus one foot for each level of the character. The character must have at least 10 feet of running space for springing. In both cases, the character must make a normal to hit roll to see if he lands safely. If the roll is made, the leap or spring is successful. If the roll is failed, the character makes the leap but falls to the ground upon landing.

Speed: The character has developed lightning-fast reflexes and powerful muscles mainly by concentrating and learning how his body controls its movements. The character gains twice the normal amount of melee attacks he is normally allowed (both with the martial arts and normal combat) and moves at double the normal combat movement rate (only). The increase in movement rate does not apply to normal movement nor can the movement speed be maintained for more than five rounds. This special maneuver is difficult and tiring. It can only be done once per day and can only be maintained for five rounds. At the end of

this time, the character must rest for 1-3 rounds.

Slow Resistance: Having developed his body and disciplined his mind, the character is automatically immune to *slow* effects.

Push

Pushing is a soft form of combat, primarily protective in nature. It relies on the character's understanding of the forces of motion. The opponent's own force is turned against him, deflecting his attack, throwing him off-balance, or knocking him backward with a single touch. Learning this art takes great mental discipline but does not require great strength.

Concentrated Push: The character focuses his inner energy into his hands, giving him great results even from a gentle push. On a successful to hit roll the opponent is knocked back one foot per level of the character. If the distance is greater than three feet, the victim must make a successful saving throw vs. paralyzation to remain on his feet. If the victim hits a solid object, he suffers damage as if he had fallen the same distance. Note that those with Immovability can resist being knocked back. If the Concentrated Push attack is unsuccessful, all attacks made against the character for the remainder of the round have a +2 on their chance to hit.

Sticking Touch: The character has so attuned his sense of touch that even by lightly placing his hand on another he can cause it to follow their every move. A normal to hit roll must be made and the touch does no damage. However, so long as the character remains in contact, he gains +2 on all subsequent hit rolls and his armor class improves by 2, since he is able to feel the impending move of his opponent before it happens. The touch can only be broken by the opponent moving in a way or at a speed beyond the abilities of the character. Thus, if the opponent had the Leap maneuver he could use this to break contact. However, if both knew this maneuver, the character could automatically choose to leap at the same time as his opponent, keeping his contact unbroken.

One Finger: This skill requires long and difficult practice. It is said that the student first learns to push a heavy bell with the touch of a single finger. He concentrates then on touching it lighter and lighter while making the bell swing even more. Finally, he reaches the point where he can make the bell move without actually touching it. At this point he has mastered One Finger.

One Finger gives the character the power of Concentrated Push without having to touch the target. The character simply concentrates and points his finger at the victim. The range is equal to one foot per character level. One Finger requires great concentration and is the only action that can be taken in the melee round regardless of the number of attacks the character has. A normal to hit roll must be made. If successful, the victim is affected as if hit by a Concentrated Push. If unsuccessful, the attack misses and has no effect.

Strike

Iron Fist: Through various toughening exercises, the character has hardened his hands so much so that they feel like steel. The character does 1d10 points of damage on each attack, if his principal body part used is the hands. If the principal body part is not the hands, the character does 1d10 points of damage on one attack per melee round.

Crushing Blow: The character is able to shatter or break hard objects with a blow of his hand. This includes wood, ceramics and masonry but not metal. The character can break 1/2" of wood or 1/4" of brittle stone per level. The DM can modify this based on the shape, hardness, and age of the object. If used against a living target, the character causes normal damage plus points equal to his level. The Crushing Blow requires great concentration and is the only action the character can do in a round regardless of the number of attacks normally allowed. In all cases a normal to hit roll must be made. The DM must determine the number needed to hit a stationary object (based on its hardness). If the die roll is failed and the character is striking a hard object (such as a stone), he has seriously hurt his hand. He suffers damage equal to what he would do on a normal attack and the hand is unusable for 24 hours.

Eagle Claw: Through physical exercise and concentration, the character can summon immense crushing strength into his hand. On a successful to hit roll he can shatter objects (snap spear shafts, crush stones, etc.), crush metal items, and cause 3d10 points of damage on an attack. This requires great concentration and is the only action the character can take during the round.

Throw

Fall: The first maneuver any student of this style learns is how to fall correctly. He learns to fall and roll, taking the impact of the fall on the safest areas of his body. Once learned this maneuver is constantly in effect. Thereafter he suffers only 1/2 the normal amount of damage from any fall.

Instant Stand: After learning to fall, the student learns how to gain his feet quickly either by rolling up to a standing position or using an acrobatic jump. Normally one round is required for a character to gain his feet, but a character knowing this maneuver can regain his feet automatically instead of making an attack. He may do other actions in the round if he has attacks available.

Hurl: This type of throw relies a great deal on strength and less on leverage. The character can attempt to pick up an opponent and throw him to the ground 1d4 feet away. The victim suffers double damage from the throw. Characters with Immovability can resist this maneuver. A successful to hit roll must be made for the Hurl to work. If the roll is failed, the character loses all remaining attacks for the round and automatically loses initiative for the

next round.

Great Throw: Using leverage and his opponent's momentum, the character is able to throw his enemy a great distance. A normal to hit roll must be made. If the victim is stationary, the character can throw him one foot per level. If the victim is charging the character, the distance thrown is six feet plus one foot per level. The victim suffers triple normal damage from the throw. If the to hit roll is unsuccessful, the opponent has countered the move and the character has been knocked off his feet, automatically losing initiative the next round.

Vital Area

This method is much like strike or kick in that it relies on the blow for effect. However, the strength of the blow is not nearly as important as where it is delivered. The vital area method teaches the character where and how to strike at the weak spot on his opponent's body—the throat, the ears, the foot, nerve points, and other places. Because the training requires a knowledge of anatomy, the special maneuvers listed can only be used against human and humanoid opponents.

Pain Touch: Simply by pressing his finger against specific points of the body, the character can cause great pain in his victim. This can be done in place of a normal attack. It causes no damage, but if the to hit roll is successful, the victim feels as if he is on fire. Thereafter, he will be -2 on his chance to hit and +2 on chance of being hit. The effect lasts for 1-3 rounds. There is no adverse effect on the victim if the to hit roll is failed.

Stunning Touch: With a light slap of his fingers in the correct place, the character can stun and daze his opponent. This can be done in place of a normal attack and causes no damage. A normal to hit roll must be made. If successful, the victim is allowed a saving throw vs. paralyzation. If this is failed, the victim is stunned for 1d4 rounds, unable to take any action. However, should the to hit roll fail or the saving throw be passed, the attack has no effect.

Paralyzing Touch: By placing pressure on specific nerve junctions, the character can paralyze his victim, leaving him unable to move for 1d6 turns. A normal to hit roll must be made and the victim is allowed a saving throw vs. paralyzation. If the attack fails or the saving throw is made, no damage is done.

Distance Death: This is the ultimate skill of this method and requires great practice and concentration. To learn it, the character must practice at a pool of water, driving his finger at it without touching it. As he does so, he concentrates on his own power, trying to extend it from his finger. When he can hear the echo of his thrust rebound from the water, he has mastered the maneuver.

Distance Death requires great concentration and is the only action the character can take during the melee round. It has a range of one foot per level of the character. With it the

character can choose to apply the effects of Pain, Stunning, or Paralyzing Touch or he can choose to do three times his normal damage on the attack. If Pain is chosen, the victim is not allowed a saving throw; for Stunning the saving throw is -2 on the die roll. In all cases a normal to hit roll must be made.

Weapon

The martial arts often include training in a number of standard and unusual weapons. The training with standard weapons is very much like that which other warriors receive and is covered elsewhere in these rules. However, there are several weapons unique to the martial arts—weapons that cannot be used effectively without training in the moves and positions associated with the martial arts. The maneuvers given below can only be applied when using those weapons that are noted as being exclusive to practitioners of the martial arts.

Weapon Catch: All weapons are routinely used to block and parry an opponent. The Weapon Catch maneuver teaches the character how to use the special martial arts weapons to catch and lock his opponent's weapon in place. Here weapon includes not just melee weapons but also the arms and legs of an unarmed opponent. A Weapon Catch is made in place of a normal attack and a to hit roll must be made. If successful, the character has caught the opponent's attack with his weapon and has locked it in place. The opponent cannot use that weapon to fight with. Furthermore, the character can make further attacks on the opponent with a +2 on his chance to hit, if he has the correct principal body part free to make the attack. The opponent can break the catch by either dropping his weapon or spending a melee attack to attempt to break free. If he attempts the latter, he must make a normal to hit roll to succeed.

If the Weapon Catch attempt fails, the character has managed to foul his own weapon on that of the opponent's. With a quick twist the opponent pulls the character's weapon from his grasp, leaving the character disarmed.

Weapon Breaker: Just as martial arts weapons are designed to catch weapons, they are also capable of breaking them. Indeed, students are often taught this art as it gives them an advantage in combat. The breaking action is a swift blow with the weapon. It can only be used against melee weapons, not unarmed fighters. The character can also use this maneuver when fighting with the bo stick against a sword. A normal to hit roll must be made. If successful, the opponent's weapon must save vs. crushing blow or be broken. If the to hit roll fails or the save is made, the maneuver fails. This maneuver does no damage.

Steel Cloth: With this maneuver, the character need never be without a weapon. Taking a 6- to 10-foot piece of cloth, the character whirls and snaps it tight, keeping it in constant motion, giving it the rigidity of a spear. The cloth is treated as a spear, except that it cannot be thrown. This maneuver is automatic, no die roll is made for success.

Mental and Physical Training

These maneuvers are gained by the character in the course of training and reflect his superb control over mind and body. They do not belong to the categories of principal methods as they can be learned by practitioners of any method or style.

Meditation: The character gains all the powers of *meditation* as explained under the shukenja character description. Shukenja and kensai, who already have this ability, do not need to spend a proficiency to gain this maneuver.

All-around Sight: The character's training makes him more attuned to his immediate surroundings. He is able to detect opponents on all sides of him, provided they are not *invisible*. The character can never be struck from behind or suffer a penalty from a back attack. This maneuver is constantly in effect.

Mental Resistance: The mental exercises and ordeals of the character's training have toughened and strengthened his will. He receives a +2 on all saving throws against mental attacks including *charm*, *illusion*, and *hold* spells. This maneuver is constantly in effect.

Blind Fighting: Under his master's guidance, the character has trained for long periods while wearing a blindfold or in darkened rooms. This has given the character the ability to detect his foes with his other senses. The character suffers only a -1 penalty when fighting in darkness, when blinded, or when faced by *invisible* opponents. However, any of these in combination with a *silence* spell render the character effectively blind again. This maneuver is constantly in effect.

Ironskin: Rigorous physical training has toughened the character's muscles to the point where he can harden them like iron. The armor class of the character is improved by 2, but only when he is not wearing any other type of armor.

Levitation: This is perhaps the rarest of all the martial arts maneuvers, since it requires the utmost of concentration and mental discipline. Daily the character practices at making his body feel lighter, using his mental power to negate his own weight. Finally, the character succeeds in overcoming all his weight. At this point he can levitate. This maneuver requires one turn of concentration before it can be done. Thereafter the character can move up, down or sideways at five feet per round. He can take no actions while levitating and if his concentration is broken, he falls to the ground. Upon completion of the Levitation, the character must rest for one round before doing any other action.

Stunning and Incapacitating

In addition to the basic abilities and the special maneuvers associated with a martial arts style, all styles have a chance of stunning or incapacitating a man-sized opponent. Whenever the martial arts fighter rolls an unmodified 20 on his to hit roll, the victim must

make a saving throw vs. paralyzation. If the saving throw is successful, the victim is not stunned or incapacitated (although he does take normal damage from the attack). If the saving throw is failed, the victim is either incapacitated or stunned. Compare the hit dice or level of the victim to the die roll. If the number rolled is less than the hit dice or level of the target, the victim is stunned for 1d6 melee rounds. If the number is greater than this, the victim is incapacitated for 1-3 hours.

A character attacks a lizard man with martial arts and scores a 20. A saving throw roll is made and 2 is rolled on the die. This is equal to the 2 + 1 dice of the lizard man, so it is stunned for 1d6 rounds. If the die roll had been 6, the creature would have been incapacitated for 1-3 hours. Creatures with a +4 or greater on their hit dice are treated as having one extra die for this calculation.

Learning Martial Arts

In some ways, learning a martial arts skill is like learning any other proficiency. The character must have a proficiency slot available and spend it on the particular martial arts style he wishes to learn. However, learning a martial art is much more difficult than learning other disciplines, so there are a few more requirements when mastering a martial art.

The character must first find a master to study under. Masters are the teachers of the martial arts. They can be anyone and can be found anywhere. The peasant in the field may also be a master of martial arts. The hermit in the hills may pass his time learning and developing his own style. The master may be a bushi skilled in these techniques who travels the countryside teaching others. He may be a professional teacher who opens a school in a city or village. He may be a famous samurai, willing to pass his skills onto others. A priest in a temple may teach his followers as part of their religious training.

Master is an honorary title, not a character class. Students refer to their teacher as master. Unarmed fighters who have gained a reputation are respectfully called master. A wanderer may enter a town proclaiming himself to be a master. The title is not a measure of the skill or level! There are brilliant masters whose names and deeds are well-known. There are skilled masters, able to teach all but the most difficult feats. There are mediocre masters, just good enough to teach the basics. And there are incompetent masters who hide their poor skills behind the imposing-sounding title. As characters study, they learn the true qualities of the master they have chosen.

Finding a master is not necessarily an easy task. Many masters regard their skills as valuable secrets to be taught to only a select few. Many a style has disappeared because the master refused to reveal his art. Often they do not advertise or even display their skill. They feel that to do so would be proud and boastful, characteristics that are undesirable in a master (and incidentally may incur the wrath of the gods). For many, the ultimate goal of

their training is to avoid having to use it. Others feel that their art can only be learned in the most tranquil and secluded surroundings, deep in mountain forests and the like. Such men seldom appear in civilized lands.

Politics are another reason masters can be hard to find. Conquered peoples are often forbidden to learn or practice their arts lest they become troublesome and rebellious. Powerful temples (often the center of such training) may be destroyed by nervous emperors, warlords, or daimyos. The master and his students are forced to scatter with the winds and many disappear without a trace. In such cases, they may join or form secret societies, clandestinely meeting on rare occasions to train.

Not all masters are such recluses or the skills of martial arts would long since have died away. A large town or city may have a master. His skill might be well-known and potential students might travel great distances to study under him. The DM can also create other schools teaching the same or different styles. As characters adventure in his campaign, they will undoubtedly hear of some of these schools or may even learn of one of the more secretive masters of martial arts.

Even after finding a master, the character is not guaranteed of training. Masters are notoriously finicky about who they take as a student. The character untrained in martial arts must first present himself to the master with, he hopes, the proper humble and respectful attitude. At this time the character has a 10% chance of being accepted outright. More often than not, the master will dismiss the applicant politely. Now the character must begin courting the master, trying to gain his favor. He must return to the master, bearing some small gift or offering. If this pleases the master (and the character's behavior is still properly respectful), the chance of acceptance is increased by 10%. The character can continue this round of visits until he is either accepted or he offends the master. Once the latter occurs the master will never accept the character as his student.

If the character already has some martial arts skill, he can challenge the master to a fight. This challenge is automatically accepted. A time and place is arranged and the master decides if he or one of his current students will fight the challenging character. If the character is not well-known for his skill, a student is automatically assigned to accept the challenge. This is customary and is not considered an insult to the character. Challenges can be fought to subdue or fought to the death. In most cases, the former is preferred since it spares unnecessary killing. However, the death of an opponent in a challenge is not considered a crime and the victor is seldom punished. Challenges are open to spectators and large crowds may gather to see the outcome. If the character wins the challenge, the master automatically accepts him as a student (although he may actually hope to learn from his pupil). If the character loses the challenge, he can leave and return at a later date when he has gained more skill, or he can humbly beg to be accepted. Such entreaties are particularly effective when the master has disposed of the challenger with humiliating ease.

After a character has been accepted by a master, the DM should determine just what the master knows about the particular style. He automatically knows the basics (which give the Armor Class, etc.). The DM should count the number of weapons used by the style (if any) and roll the nearest die that is equal to or greater than this number. The result is the number of special weapons the master is proficient in. The DM should then total the number of special maneuvers available to the style and roll the nearest die that is equal to or greater than this number. This gives the number of maneuvers the master is proficient in. Special maneuvers are always known from those of lowest difficulty upward (the master is under the same restriction as characters for learning special maneuvers). Once this is determined, these are the things the master can teach. The master never increases in knowledge unless the DM rules that special circumstances dictate otherwise.

Once a character has been accepted by a master, he must remain and study under him for at least one month. At the end of this time, the character spends one proficiency slot and gains the basics of the style—the Armor Class, number of attacks, and damage. He does not gain any of the special maneuvers or weapons that may be taught by the style. At this point, the character does not need to remain with the master constantly. He is free to travel and adventure. He must practice his style for at least one hour a day and must spend six hours per week working with his master. Characters who do not fulfill this obligation cannot add more special maneuvers and weapons.

To learn the special maneuvers and weapons of a particular style, the character must spend additional proficiency slots. For each proficiency slot expended, the character can add one special maneuver or weapon from the style. This does not mean the character just suddenly knows how to do it, but assumes that he has been practicing prior to gaining the maneuver or weapon proficiency. No more than two proficiency slots can be expended on a single martial arts style per level. Special maneuvers must be learned in order of difficulty. All difficulty 1 maneuvers must be learned before the character can progress to difficulty 2 maneuvers, and so forth.

When a character has learned all the knowledge the master knows, there is no point for him to study under the master. The character can now go off in search of another master—one who knows more about the style or one who teaches a different style.

Multiple Styles and Combining Styles

Player characters can learn more than one style of martial arts at a time. This requires more than one master, available proficiency slots, and dedication on the part of the player character. When fighting, the character must choose which particular style he will use. He gains all the abilities of that style, but none of the other style he knows. Likewise only the special maneuvers of the style can be used, unless they are constantly in effect. The character can change styles from melee round to melee round, however.

After a player character has gained proficiency in two or more styles and has learned all he can from those masters, he can create his own unique style. To create a unique style, the character combines those elements of each style as he desires. He could use the Armor Class of one style combined with the number of attacks and damage of another. All the maneuvers he has learned from each style can be combined in the new single style. He can also instruct others in this new style as if he were a master.